

What went wrong for Harmanpreet Kaur & Co.?

As India grapples with yet another **World Cup heartbreak**, there may be lingering questions about whether the middle-order could've been braver with the bat.

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A World Cup in Asia without a single Asian side in the knockouts — not the best endorsement of the subcontinent's cricketing passion or the robustness of its cricketing systems. Yet, here we are.

India is the only side from the Asian quartet to have previously reached the World Cup semifinals. Expectations were high this time, especially given India had made the knockouts five times in the previous eight editions. The positive results leading up to the T20 showpiece, combined with a carefully selected squad after extensive experimentation, only heightened those expectations. However, a group-stage exit felt like a damp, deflating end.

New World Cup, old problems

Since the 2023 T20 World Cup in South Africa, India played 29 T20Is, with two no-results and nine losses. Preparing for a World Cup in Bangladesh, India faced Nigar Sultana's side twice. A 1-1 series draw was also played against South Africa at home in spin-friendly Chennai, anticipating similar conditions in Bangladesh. The Asia Cup final loss to Sri Lanka was unexpected. India

had cruised to the final with comfortable wins against Pakistan, UAE, and Nepal in the group stage, followed by a thumping of Bangladesh in the semifinal.

However, Sri Lanka's planning paid off. Chamari Athapaththu's side shocked India with an eight-wicket victory in front of a raucous Dambulla crowd, earning a maiden Asian crown.

India's senior team did not play an international bilateral series between the Asia Cup and the T20 World Cup, which was eventually moved to the UAE. A few players participated in franchise cricket — some in The Hundred, others in the Caribbean Premier League. For the rest, preparations largely came from two camps at the National Cricket Academy in Bengaluru: a fitness and fielding camp and a skill camp.

"It wasn't just net sessions at the skills camp; the players played almost five games in 10 days. So if you ask for game time, we've ticked that box. We played some very competitive games with different oppositions and varied skill sets," head coach Amol Muzumdar said at the time.

In hindsight, opponents and skills weren't the problem as much as adapting quickly to conditions. India faltered in its first game in Dubai against New Zealand, unable to get a grip on the proceedings. That 54-run loss to a team on a 10-match losing

streak derailed India's momentum. A hapless batting performance saw it manage just 108 in response to New Zealand's 160/4, crippling its Net Run Rate (NRR).

India bounced back to thrash Pakistan by six wickets, but again, the batters struggled on a slow, low track, taking 18.5 overs to chase 105, which did nothing to improve its NRR.

At that stage, while players echoed the usual 'focus on process' and 'seal the win' rhetoric, Shafali Verma was refreshingly candid, saying, "When you're a player for India, you don't need to be told about things like NRR. It's always on your mind."

India's best performance, an 82-run win, came against Sri Lanka. Fifties from Harmanpreet Kaur and Smriti Mandhana powered India to 172, the highest score of the competition this year. Sri Lanka fell short, with Athapaththu unable to find form when it mattered.

In India's final group game, needing a win against Australia to stay in contention, it fell short chasing 152. Once again, an age-old problem — maintaining composure in pressure situations — surfaced. Needing 14 runs from the final over, India lost four wickets, with Harmanpreet, who had kept her side in the game with an unbeaten half-century, stranded at the other end.